Playable but Private: In-Encoder Selective Encryption with Ascon-AEAD128 and Attack-Adaptive Protection for MJPEG Video on an FPGA SoC

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***Abstract*—Small video cameras increasingly stream to networks they do not control, yet encrypting the whole stream makes it unplayable without the key and spends energy on every byte. We present a JPEG/MJPEG encoder for a Zynq-7020 FPGA SoC that encrypts only the sign and amplitude bits of selected DCT coefficients, at the entropy-coding stage and with a keystream from the NIST SP 800-232 lightweight standard Ascon-AEAD128. Huffman code lengths are untouched, so every protection level remains a valid JPEG stream, while a 128-bit tag computed over the frame metadata and the coded scan lets the receiver reject any modified, replayed or forged frame. The register-transfer-level design is verified bit-exact against a Python golden model and needs no additional clock cycles for encryption in any mode. Around the encoder we build an authenticated feedback channel, a key ratchet and an adaptive policy that raises protection when the receiver reports attacks. In a networked simulation, all 11 active attacks we model were mitigated in 0.91 s on average with no false alarms, and on 7 video clips and the Kodak images a keyed block shuffle removed the outline leakage that sign and amplitude encryption alone leave behind, also against a jigsaw solver and a trained neural attacker; the same network defeats sign-only encryption. We also report a negative result: a learning bandit policy saves 14 % of encrypted bits but reacts more slowly than a fixed threshold rule.**

***Index Terms*—selective encryption, MJPEG, Ascon, lightweight cryptography, FPGA, authenticated encryption, video surveillance**

I. Introduction

Cameras on doors, corridors and machines now send video over Wi-Fi and shared Ethernet as a matter of course. Two properties matter for such a link. Confidentiality keeps a bystander on the network from watching the scene; integrity lets the viewer trust that what it shows was captured by the camera and not edited, replayed or injected on the way. The usual answer, encrypting the transport with TLS, SRTP [1] or a VPN, provides both, but it hides the stream from every tool that is not part of the key infrastructure and costs cipher work proportional to the full bitrate.

Selective encryption takes a different route: it encrypts only the parts of the compressed representation that carry most of the visual information, and leaves the format intact so that standard decoders still parse the result [2]. For JPEG, the sign and appended amplitude bits of the DCT coefficients can be encrypted without changing any Huffman code length, so the bitstream stays compliant and its size does not grow [3], [4]. The price is that such schemes are easy to weaken: the positions of non-zero coefficients stay visible, and an attacker who guesses the hidden values can still see outlines [2], [5].

This work starts from a practical question: how much of a secure camera link can be put into the encoder hardware itself, and what does an eavesdropper still learn? We make four contributions.

1) An MJPEG encoder in synthesizable Verilog in which an Ascon-AEAD128 [6], [7] keystream is XORed onto coefficient signs and amplitudes as they are entropy-coded, with no added cycles and closing timing at 100 MHz on a Zynq-7020, a parallel-lane variant over JPEG restart segments that reaches 176 Mpixel/s at the same clock, and a per-frame tag that binds the coded scan to the protection level, session, frame counter and image size (Section III).
2) Six protection levels, from tag-only to a keyed shuffle of macroblocks, evaluated against five keyless attackers (value replacement, the sign-recovery program of Lin et al., a jigsaw solver, a trained U-Net and a chosen-plaintext attack) on a synthetic scene, 7 real video clips (2 of them openly licensed) and the Kodak image set, with the cost of restart intervals and the frame-size channel that no level hides (Sections V and VII).
3) An authenticated feedback loop with a forward-secure key ratchet and an adaptive policy, evaluated against 11 active attacks and benign impairments; a threshold rule is compared with a contextual bandit over 10 paired seeds (Section VI).
4) A verification flow in which a Python golden model is the reference for every stage: Ascon matches all official known-answer tests, and every RTL block matches the model bit for bit.

II. Related Work

Selective encryption of JPEG. Van Droogenbroeck and Benedett encrypted the appended bits of selected AC coefficients of baseline JPEG so that the stream stays compliant

at a constant bit rate [3]. Puech and Rodrigues encrypted selected DCT coefficients of medical images with AES [8], and Auer et al. encrypted baseline JPEG at bitstream level with an AES-OFB generator at more than 25 VGA frames per second, preserving length and format [4]. Massoudi et al. survey the field and note that visual distortion is subjective and does not measure security: replacement and chosen-plaintext attacks recover more than the scrambled image suggests [2]. Lin et al. show that DCT sign bits can be recovered by optimization [5], which bounds what sign-only encryption can promise. Hirose et al. analyse JPEG encryption that shuffles blocks delimited by restart markers [9]; our strongest level uses the same mechanism with a keyed permutation. Li et al. recover block-shuffled JPEG with a designed plaintext that reveals the permutation [10]. Selective encryption has also been extended to H.264/AVC and HEVC [11].

Hardware. Kishore et al. added PN-sequence block and symbol scrambling to an FPGA JPEG encoder; their tables show 13–17 % more ALUTs and 9–10 % fewer frames per second with it [12], and Bağbaba and Örs combined an FPGA JPEG encoder with TEA encryption of the DC and first five AC coefficients [13]. Neither authenticates the frames. Ascon, now standardized by NIST in SP 800-232 [6], [7], is small and fast in hardware (about 7 kGE for a core with one unrolled round) [14]; Gladis Kurian and Chen implement Ascon on an Artix-7 with replay detection through a Bloom filter in block RAM [15].

Traffic analysis. Sizes and timing of encrypted streams reveal motion [16] and which video is played [17]; traffic shaping hides IoT activity at up to $18\times$ the bandwidth for a camera [18].

Gap. We found no design that (i) places a standardized lightweight AEAD inside a hardware JPEG encoder at the entropy-coding stage, (ii) keeps every protection level playable while authenticating each frame together with its metadata, and (iii) closes the loop from the receiver back to the encoder so that the protection level follows observed attacks. We also could not find an evaluation of the outline leakage of such schemes against learned attackers on real video.

III. System Design

A. Threat model

The attacker sits on the network path. It may observe all traffic, and it may modify, drop, delay, replay or inject both video and feedback datagrams; it does not hold the keys. A passive eavesdropper sends nothing, so it cannot be detected; against it only the configured minimum protection level helps. Physical and side-channel attacks on the device are out of scope. The assets are the visual content of each frame, the integrity of content and metadata (protection level, session, counter and size), and the availability signal that tells the viewer the camera is alive. A (key, nonce) pair never repeats: the 63-bit frame counter only increases within a run, every rekey changes both the key and the session identifier, and every boot draws a fresh 48-bit random session base.

B. Encoder and cipher integration

Fig. 1 shows the datapath of a baseline JPEG encoder [19], [20]: colour conversion with 4:2:0 subsampling, a two-pass integer DCT, a reciprocal-multiplication quantiser, zig-zag ordering with run-length coding, the encryption stage, Huffman coding and a bit packer. The whole datapath is fixed-point and mirrors the golden model operation for operation, so the hardware output can be compared byte by byte.

The keystream generator runs Ascon-AEAD128 on an all-zero message under the frame nonce, one permutation round per clock cycle, and keeps a small buffer of keystream bits ahead of the encryption stage. For each coefficient the encryption stage consumes keystream bits only for the fields the protection level selects. If the sign is selected and the next keystream bit is one, all bits of the coefficient's appended amplitude field are inverted; in JPEG's one's-complement amplitude coding this is exactly a sign change. If amplitudes are selected, the remaining bits are XORed onto the lower bits of the field. The size category, and therefore the Huffman code, is never changed. As a result the encrypted scan has the same length as the plain one, and the keystream generator works in parallel with the rest of the pipeline.

A second Ascon instance computes the tag. Its associated data is a 26-byte prefix (format identifier, version, protection level, 64-bit session identifier, 64-bit frame counter, width and height) followed by every byte of the coded scan. The ARM core adds standard JPEG headers and an APP11 segment that carries the prefix and the tag; ordinary viewers skip this segment. Binding the level into the tag matters: an earlier version did not, and a frame could be downgraded undetected.

The 128-bit nonce concatenates the 64-bit session identifier with the 63-bit frame counter and one purpose bit that separates the keystream from the tag computation. The session identifier holds 48 random bits and the current key epoch.

C. Protection levels

Every level carries the per-frame tag. E0 encrypts nothing (authentication only), E1 the AC sign bits, E2 also the DC-difference signs (default minimum), E3 also the AC amplitude bits, E4 also the DC amplitude bits, and E5 adds a keyed permutation of 16×16 macroblocks. Sign and amplitude encryption cannot hide which coefficients are non-zero, because the Huffman symbols reveal run lengths and size categories. E5 therefore inserts a restart marker after every macroblock and permutes the resulting segments with a Fisher–Yates shuffle driven by Ascon under a separately derived key. Restart markers keep the stream decodable but cost 12–21 % bitrate over E4 in our measurements (320×240 and 640×480), whereas E2 adds only the 38-byte APP11 segment (0.3–0.5 %). E5 is implemented in the golden model; restart-marker support in the RTL is ongoing work.

D. Feedback, keys and adaptive protection

The receiver authenticates every frame, checks the counter against a 64-entry replay window as in SRTP [1], and returns heartbeats every 0.5 s and rate-limited alerts. Feedback

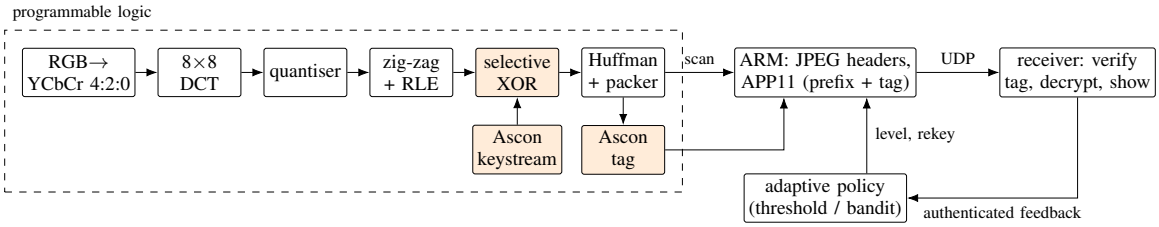


Fig. 1. Encoder datapath with in-loop encryption (shaded) and the feedback loop. The keystream is consumed only for the fields selected by the protection level; the tag covers the frame metadata and the coded scan.

messages are themselves Ascon-AEAD128 encrypted under a separate key and protected by their own replay window. The video key is advanced by a one-way ratchet, $K_{e+1} = \mathrm{KDF}(K_e, \text{“ratchet”}, e{+}1)$, so a key captured later does not expose earlier epochs. A dead-man rule treats three seconds without a valid heartbeat as an attack: the sender switches to the highest level and rekeys.

The sender's ARM core collects evidence in one-second windows: tag failures, replays, malformed or stale frames, frame loss over three windows, forged feedback and unexpected traffic. Two policies map this evidence to a protection level. The *threshold* policy escalates to the highest level on strong evidence, holds it for 8 s, and rekeys on bursts of tag failures. The *bandit* policy is an ε-greedy contextual bandit [21] over a small discrete context, with optimistic initial values and sample-average updates; its reward penalizes leakage weighted by the evidence of attack, encrypted bits and level switches. Neither policy goes below the configured minimum level.

IV. Implementation and Verification

The golden model is written in Python and implements Ascon, the integer transforms, entropy coding, encryption and the container format. It passes all 1089 official Ascon-AEAD128 known-answer tests. Each RTL block has a cocotb testbench that drives random inputs with random back-pressure and compares every output with the model; the top level is compared byte for byte for E0–E4 with 64-bit session identifiers and counters above 2^{32}. A self-checking Verilog-2001 testbench encodes five frames in all five levels and is bit-exact with the model both in Icarus Verilog and in Vivado's simulator (XSim 2026.1).

In RTL simulation of a 160×128 frame, the cycle counts of E0–E4 differ by at most 2 cycles, which is handshake noise rather than encryption work: encryption costs no cycles. Above the floor of 1.5 cycles per pixel that 4:2:0 sampling sets, the only cost is filling the first MCU row: on five frame sizes the RTL needs $1.5 + 1.22/r$ cycles per pixel for r MCU rows, 1.64 at 160×128 and 1.53 at 640×480. After place and route in Vivado it meets 100 MHz on the xc7z020 (WNS +0.554 ns, out of context, I/O delays of 20 % of the period), i.e. 65 Mpixel/s or 212 frames/s at 640×480.Table I gives the resources (5,037 LUTs, 9.5 % of the device; about 223 mW, vectorless estimate). The two Ascon instances take 46 % of the LUTs, and all 24 BRAM36 are the converter's MCU-row buffers, sized for 2048-pixel lines. In Table II, each of our Ascon cores (861–969 LUTs) is as small as the round-per-cycle Ascon-p cores of [22], and our JPEG datapath uses fewer LUTs than the commercial encoders [23], [24], which however process one sample per clock at 150–166 MHz with less block RAM. Coding MCU-row restart segments in four parallel lanes (contract v3) gives 176 Mpixel/s at 100 MHz in RTL simulation, bit-exact, and closes 100 MHz after place and route (16,573 LUTs), as do both complete PYNQ-Z2 systems.

TABLE I
Resources on the xc7z020 (53 200 LUT, 106 400 FF, 140 BRAM36, 220 DSP). Source: Vivado post-route, out of context, 100 MHz with I/O delays of 20 % of the period, WNS +0.554 ns; power is Vivado's vectorless estimate.

Block	LUT	FF	BRAM36	DSP
Encoder (all)	5037 (9.5%)	2950 (2.8%)	24.5 (17.5%)	23 (10.4%)
colour conversion + line buffers	762	215	24	0
DCT and quantizer	806	69	0	22
zig-zag, Huffman, packing	720	323	0	0
keystream generator (Ascon)	950	851	0	0
tag unit (Ascon)	1345	1072	0	0
selective encryption	82	24	0	0
AXI-Lite registers	351	355	0	0

TABLE II
Comparison with published FPGA designs. Their numbers are as reported by each source; ours are post-route (Table I) with throughput from the RTL cycle count of a 640×480 frame. Mpx/s: million pixels per second. Lanes (v3): throughput in RTL simulation at 100 MHz, area post-route.

Design	Device	LUT	BRAM	DSP	MHz	Mpx/s	Crypto
Ours: encoder	Zynq-7020	5,037	24.5	23	100	65	sel. AEAD
Ours: one Ascon	Zynq-7020	861–969	0	0	100	–	AEAD core
Ours: 4 lanes (v3)	Zynq-7020	16,573	52.0	92	100	176	sel. AEAD
logiJPGE [23]	Zynq-7020	3,240	16	30	150	150	none
CAST JPEG-E-S [24]	Artix-7	3,069	2	16	166	–	none
Khairallah [22]	Artix-7	1,031	0	0	200	–	MAC
Kurian [15]	Artix-7	5,335	32	0	100	–	AEAD

V. Security Evaluation

Setup. We measure what a keyless observer can reconstruct. For every frame we take the better of two pictures: the protected stream decoded as is, and a *replacement attack* that substitutes fixed guesses for the encrypted values (absolute values for encrypted signs, the smallest value of the size category for encrypted amplitudes, zero DC differences) and re-encodes a valid JPEG. Leakage is the Pearson correlation between the Sobel gradient magnitudes of this picture and of the original (edge correlation); we also report SSIM [25].

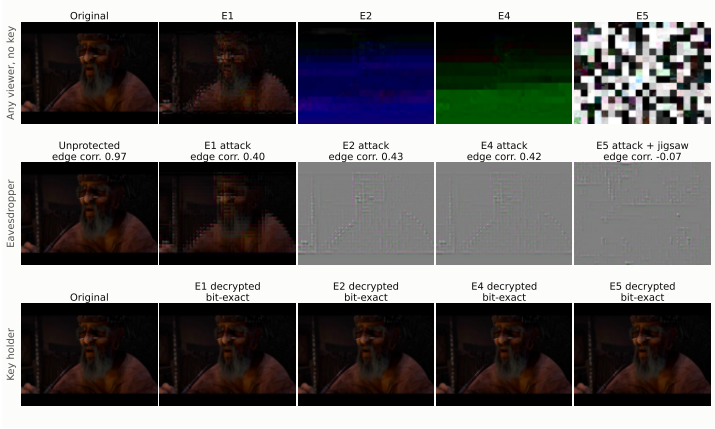


Fig. 2. One frame of the Sintel trailer (© Blender Foundation, CC BY 3.0) per protection level. Top: what any viewer shows without the key. Middle: the eavesdropper's best reconstruction (replacement attack; for E5 followed by the jigsaw solver) with its edge correlation. Bottom: the key holder's output, bit-exact with the unprotected encoder.

Sources are a synthetic corridor scene; 5 clips that we analyse but do not reproduce (two film trailers, two talking-head videos and a handheld phone video, identified by hash); 2 openly licensed films of the Blender Foundation, the Sintel trailer and Tears of Steel (CC BY 3.0)[1]; and the 24 images of the Kodak set[2]. Video is resized to 320×240 and sampled every 150 frames; frames without edges are excluded.

Format compliance. The protected streams of all six levels decode without error in Pillow, OpenCV, scikit-image, FFmpeg (MJPEG), at the original resolution.

Outline leakage. Fig. 2 and Table III show the main effect. Under E1–E4 the eavesdropper sees a clear outline of the scene: edge correlation stays between 0.28 and 0.56 on the real sources, and encrypting amplitudes in addition to signs (E3, E4) does not reduce it, because the positions and size categories of the non-zero coefficients remain public. The keyed macroblock permutation of E5 removes the outline (edge correlation between -0.007 and 0.014). In terms of cost, E2 encrypts 13.4 % of the bits, E4 29.5 %, and E5 only slightly more, 30.9 %, yet only E5 moves leakage to zero.

Jigsaw attacker. A permutation of blocks invites a puzzle solver. Our greedy region-growing solver in the style of [26] restores most neighbour relations on unencrypted shuffled tiles. On E5 replacement-attack tiles it places at most 1.7 % of neighbour pairs correctly, and the solved picture has no outline (Table III). The structure is not destroyed, only hidden: an oracle that knew the permutation would recover edge correlations of 0.32–0.47. A minimum-spanning-tree solver with Mahalanobis gradient compatibility [27], which restores at least 0.84 of the neighbours on unencrypted tiles of six photos (greedy: 0.62), is also at chance on E5 (at most 2.5 % on nine sources). A chosen-plaintext attack [10] fails too: the permutation comes from the frame nonce, so on all eight sources one frame's exact permutation places at most 0.4 % of the next frame's 300 tiles (chance) and leaves edge correlation ≤0.02, where a key-only shuffle would give 0.28–0.47.

[1]https://durian.blender.org, https://mango.blender.org

[2]http://r0k.us/graphics/kodak/

TABLE III

OUTLINE LEAKAGE: EDGE CORRELATION BETWEEN THE ORIGINAL AND THE EAVESDROPPER'S BEST KEYLESS RECONSTRUCTION (DECODE OR REPLACEMENT ATTACK; 0 = NO OUTLINE), UP TO 60 FRAMES PER SOURCE; FRAMES WITHOUT EDGES ARE SKIPPED. THE FIRST ROW IS THE FRACTION OF PAYLOAD BITS ENCRYPTED. JIG.: SHARE OF NEIGHBOUR PAIRS A GREEDY JIGSAW SOLVER RESTORES UNDER E5 (8 FRAMES; SINTEL 3); ORACLE: EDGE CORRELATION IF EVERY E5 BLOCK WERE PUT BACK IN PLACE, I.E. THE OUTLINE E5 HIDES.

Source	E0	E1	E2	E3	E4	E5	Jig. (%)	Oracle
Enc. share	0.00	0.11	0.13	0.26	0.29	0.31		
Synthetic	1.00	0.38	0.36	0.38	0.38	0.00	2.3	0.37
Trailer A	0.99	0.47	0.30	0.32	0.28	0.01	1.4	0.46
Trailer B	0.99	0.56	0.34	0.33	0.32	0.01	1.3	0.41
Talk A	0.99	0.51	0.45	0.44	0.44	0.01	1.4	0.45
Talk B	0.99	0.49	0.40	0.42	0.40	0.01	1.7	0.47
Phone A	0.99	0.45	0.35	0.34	0.33	0.00	–	–
Sintel	0.99	0.35	0.29	0.31	0.28	-0.01	0.8	0.42
Tears of Steel	0.99	0.45	0.35	0.34	0.35	-0.01	1.3	0.41
Kodak	0.99	0.39	0.33	0.34	0.31	0.00	1.3	0.32

Sign-bit recovery. The linear program of Lin et al. [5], which recovers 88–93 % of the signs in their setting (only the first three or six AC signs of a block unknown), recovers 59 % of E1's, where every AC sign is hidden, and 49 % of E2's (chance 50 %). It still sharpens E1's keyless picture (edge 0.41 against 0.33 for the replacement attack): E1–E4 leak outlines however the hidden values are guessed.

Learned attacker. We trained a U-Net [28] to map the two keyless pictures (decoded and replacement attack) to the original and always tested it on clips it had not seen (Table IV). The largest, P4, trains on 3,417 frames of four sources.The network defeats sign-only encryption: under E1 it reaches an edge correlation of 0.69 and SSIM 0.79 (replacement attack: 0.40), so E1 is no protection against a trained attacker. Under E2 and E4 it adds little to the outline that replacement already reveals (edge correlation 0.37–0.43 against 0.39) but raises

TABLE IV
U-NET RECONSTRUCTION, SSIM / EDGE CORR. ON UNSEEN TEST CLIPS. P1: TRAILER A→B, P2: TALK A→B, P3: SINTEL→TEARS OF STEEL, P4: FOUR SOURCES→THREE OTHERS. REPL.: REPLACEMENT ATTACK, P4 TEST SET. LAST ROW: THE MEDIAN TRAINING FRAME, SCORED WITHOUT LOOKING AT THE STREAM.

Mode	Repl.	P1	P2	P3	P4
E1	0.57 / 0.40	0.72 / 0.53	0.70 / 0.66	0.55 / 0.41	0.79 / 0.69
E2	0.21 / 0.39	0.42 / 0.33	0.27 / 0.34	0.14 / 0.31	0.37 / 0.43
E4	0.22 / 0.38	0.43 / 0.34	0.28 / 0.32	0.13 / 0.30	0.36 / 0.37
E5	0.18 / 0.01	0.34 / -0.02	0.26 / 0.02	0.22 / 0.00	0.34 / 0.03
No key, no stream	–	–	–	0.21 / 0.04	0.25 / -0.00

SSIM to about 0.37 by learning brightness and colour. As a control we score the median training frame, which uses no ciphertext (last row of Table IV). Under E5 the network beats this prior by 0.09 SSIM in P4, but no more than the same frame recoloured with each test frame's true colour statistics, an oracle of frame-level statistics (SSIM 0.34 [0.33, 0.36] against 0.36 [0.34, 0.37]; edge correlation 0.034 against 0.043). What it learns from the stream is brightness and colour, not the shape of the scene. P5, trained with an adversarial loss [29] on public films (Elephants Dream and Tears of Steel), gains nothing on E5 (SSIM 0.26, edge -0.01) on six unseen sources. A Faster R-CNN detector [30] finds 68–100 % of the 900 persons in the unprotected frames of eight sources, at most 3 % under E2 and E4 and none under E5.

Restart interval. E5 costs 8–23 % over E4 at 320×240, mostly for a restart marker per macroblock. Segments of N macroblocks cut this to 0.5 % at N=32, and the non-zero counting attack of [9] stays at chance (correlation $\leq$0.08) for every N; but at N=32 a beam-search solver links 0.15–0.41 of the segments to their true successor (chance 0.11), so we keep N=1.

Standard metrics. Key sensitivity holds on all 8 sources (one-bit key change: 77.5–99.5 % of pixels differ); correlation, entropy and NPCR assume a full-image cipher and are reported in our repository for comparability only.

VI. PROTOCOL AND DEFENCE EVALUATION

Setup. Sender, network channel, receiver and logger run as separate processes that talk over UDP, so the evaluation exercises the real wire format, fragmentation and timing. The sender encodes 320×240 video at 10 frames/s with the golden model (same bytes as the RTL). The channel can impose loss, delay, jitter and reordering, and it implements the attacker of our threat model. All runs used a 4-core cloud virtual machine.

Active attacks. The full scenario applies 11 attacks for six seconds each, 25 s apart: bit flips in the scan, a mode downgrade in the header, splicing of two frames, injection of a forged frame, replay, delay, dropping, a junk flood, and dropping, forging and replaying feedback. Table V gives the result over 3 runs. Every attack was mitigated in every run, on average 0.91 ± 0.02 s after it began, with 0/375 false alarms in calm windows and a median frame latency of 97 ms. The slowest case, dropped feedback, is caught only by the dead-man rule, after about 3.5 s: the 3 s timeout plus part of a decision window. With a trailer, a talking-head clip or Tears of Steel as the video source instead of the synthetic scene, all attacks were again mitigated (11/11, 11/11 and 11/11; means 0.89, 1.09 and 1.12 s, one run each) without false alarms.

TABLE V
REACTION TO EACH ACTIVE ATTACK (FULL SUITE, THRESHOLD POLICY, 3 RUNS; MEAN ± S.D. IN SECONDS). "FIRST REJECTION" IS WHEN THE RECEIVER FIRST DISCARDS A FRAME; "MITIGATED" IS WHEN THE SENDER HAS RAISED PROTECTION OR REKEYED.

Attack	Mitigated	First rejection	Mitigated after
bit flips in the scan	3/3	0.09 ± 0.03	0.41 ± 0.02
mode downgrade in header	3/3	0.06 ± 0.02	0.44 ± 0.02
splice of two frames	3/3	0.13 ± 0.00	0.46 ± 0.01
forged frame injection	3/3	0.14 ± 0.06	0.44 ± 0.03
frame replay	3/3	0.07 ± 0.05	0.46 ± 0.03
frame delay	3/3	4.13 ± 0.04	1.46 ± 0.03
frame dropping	3/3	–	1.46 ± 0.03
junk flood	3/3	–	0.49 ± 0.04
feedback dropping	3/3	–	3.47 ± 0.05
forged feedback	3/3	–	0.46 ± 0.04
feedback replay	3/3	–	0.44 ± 0.01

Benign impairments. A second scenario applies only network problems: rising packet loss up to 6 %, delay up to 120 ms with jitter, and 5 % reordering. Over 3 runs the defence raised no false alarm (0/447 windows); median latency was 82 ms and the 95th percentile 278 ms.

Threshold rule against bandit. Over 10 paired seeds of a scenario with repeated bit-flip and replay attacks, the bandit encrypted fewer bits in every seed (0.162 against 0.188, 14 % less) but reacted later (1.34 against 0.46 s) and leaked more under attack (0.054 against almost zero); neither raised a false alarm. The threshold rule stays the default.

Cost relative to software. A desktop processor is the wrong baseline (libjpeg-turbo: 0.95 ms per 640×480 frame); what matters is the SoC's ARM core, which has no AES instructions.[TODO: ARM Cortex-A9 baseline (libjpeg-turbo, AES-GCM, selective encryption in C), FPGA frame rate and energy per frame measured on the PYNQ-Z2 (GUIDE.md A1–A4, B1)]

VII. DISCUSSION AND LIMITATIONS

Four limitations bound our claims. First, our hardware numbers are post-route and the power figure is a vectorless estimate; board measurements (DMA, DDR, power) are pending, and E5 exists only in the golden model. Second, sign and amplitude encryption leak outlines by construction, however many bits are encrypted; only a change of block positions removes them, at a bitrate cost. Third, encryption hides content, not length: frame sizes reveal motion at every level alike [16]. They also identify a known video [17]: ten frame sizes pick the right one of 7 videos 98 % of the time under E1–E4 and 99 % under E5 (chance 14 %). Constant-size frames close the channel, cheaply for a fixed camera but at up to +179 % bytes on edited clips; padding to the largest frame so far gives 0.54 for +3 % on the fixed camera (0.54–0.78 on the real clips), while bitrate regulation lets up to 42 %

of frames exceed a cap. Fourth, our attackers are greedy or trained on a few clips; stronger puzzle solvers or attackers trained on large video corpora may extract more from E5, and a trained network already undoes sign-only encryption (E1). On the protocol side, the receiver cannot tell heavy benign loss from partial jamming, so only near-total suppression escalates, and the reaction time is bounded below by the one-second decision window.

VIII. Conclusion

Encrypting coefficient signs and amplitudes with Ascon inside a JPEG encoder costs no cycles, keeps every protection level playable, and, combined with a per-frame tag over metadata and scan, turns a plain MJPEG stream into an authenticated one. Without a keyed change of block positions, however, an eavesdropper still sees the outline of the scene, and no level hides the frame sizes. A closed feedback loop answers active attacks within about a second in simulation. Next are on-board results on the PYNQ-Z2, macroblock shuffling and size padding in hardware, a shared Ascon core, and key derivation with the standard's extendable-output function.

Acknowledgment

We thank Dr. Chetana G for her guidance. [TODO: AI-assistance disclosure as required by the conference (see paper/README.md): name the tools and what they were used for, e.g. code generation, test scaffolding and language editing.]

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